Swadesamitran alleged that he was sentenced solely on policeman Venkatavaradachari's evidence with no defence witnesses being called.[10]

So tilted was the situation against the Swadeshi employees that an angry VOC, in a public meeting on 3 March, declared: 'I am going to give up the Managership of the *Swadeshi* office and am ready to take up the cases and plead for all persons against whom false cases are trumped up. I will take up such cases to the High Court without fees. I won't allow the concoction of the British Indian Steam Navigation Company. I won't allow the case to be tried in this district. Hereafter we will be charged for riot, affray, etc.'[11]

In employing such intimidatory methods the administration blamed the victim: it alleged that it was the employees of the Swadeshi company who were harassing BI's customers and passengers rather than the other way round.

C. Thambusami Pillai, the lapsed Swadeshi whom we encountered in an earlier chapter, testified that he was 'in fear' of VOC and some toughs in his employ; he also claimed to have overheard the conversation of a cattle-shipper's clerk about a threat from rowdies.[12] Interested evidence such as this was used to harass SSNCo's employees.

Eating houses were often the locus for attracting passengers. Passengers bound for Colombo and the upcountry tea estates came to Tuticorin from all over the presidency. After arriving by train, their first resort was the local inns to freshen up and have a meal before purchasing tickets for their voyage. Many innkeepers, fired by the Swadeshi propaganda, directed passengers to the Swadeshi company. The police sent for some hotelkeepers, threatened them and even arrested a few.[13] The local sub-magistrate, one Mr Nay himself 'did not blush to go to each hotelkeeper here and ask him to send his customers to the B.I.S.N. and utilize his Magisterial prestige against the Swadeshi company'.[14] The bullying of eating-house keepers was even raised with the Governor Lawley but to no avail.

Not only were its employees and supporters harassed, SSNCo itself came under direct fire. Steam vessels are notorious water guzzlers. In the days